



Made to fit

The search for a tailored netbook OS ends here...

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So you've bought a brand new netbook and you've got Windows XP Home on it. If you chose a really cheap netbook, you would have one with Linux or maybe no oper-

ating system at all. There have to be a few tweaks and modifications before that OS can be deemed usable. Netbooks were designed for people using the internet for browsing, chatting, downloading, etc. Quite a few distributions have come up in the last few months with cloud computing kept in mind.

They've also been designed to keep computing really simple. Google's Chrome OS is one of the first to approach computing this way.

These pages should introduce you to some of the best netbook operating systems available for free on the internet. Obviously, you

wouldn't want to buy a cheap little netbook and then spend a bomb on an operating system that isn't properly designed to be used. Google's Chrome OS isn't fully ready as an OS for download. Some of the distributions have been put on this month's DVDs and some in the past.

Jolicloud

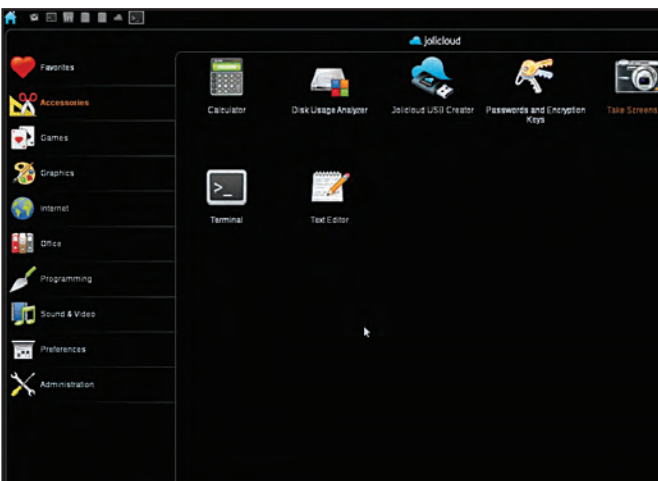
www.jolicloud.com

Jolicloud is one of the more flamboyant Linux-powered netbook operating systems around. It's definitely not lightweight or compact at around 600MB. Something about the interface makes it look very much like a very sleek phone or PDA interface - fine lines, colourful icons on a black background on a compact netbook screen.

The OS can be run as a Live OS on a USB drive and also can be installed easily on a flash drive. Performance once installed is decent - bootup and loading of the user interface is slow though. The great thing

about Jolicloud is that it's not just a cloud-based OS. Applications are available locally and many more can be downloaded with its built-in installer that downloads programs for you. Web-based addons are available as well - the number of applications keeps on increasing. With these apps, you can now open up your Twitter and Facebook accounts like you would say, Google Talk.

The end result is a very interactive, yet very usable computing experience. The interface and way of doing things is simple for anyone to get used to. Data is still stored locally.



Ubuntu Netbook Remix



www.canonical.com/projects/ubuntu/unr

When you first start up Ubuntu Netbook Remix, it's almost like Ubuntu's desktop but with the same layout as some of the other netbook distros around. The panels contain most of what makes up the desktop Ubuntu distribution. The default Ubuntu theme is also maintained. It feels as light or heavy as the default desktop distribution as well. Installation steps are also very similar.

When you get it running, you'll notice many more settings you can fool around with. Unlike Jolicloud or some of the other netbook operating systems, Ubuntu Netbook Remix doesn't hide away all the settings dialog boxes - it simply puts them in a format that netbook distributions have come to use.

This is another distribu-

tion that allows saving and accessing files stored on a local drive than using the cloud. There is however, Cloud One that you can register for. Cloud One is Ubuntu's online web space that can be used to sync all of your important documents. This has been integrated well with UNR. Being Ubuntu, you have loads of applications from the repository that can be installed. One of the hiccups we noticed was the short period of time where the application starting runs in a window mode and then maximizes.

Easy Peasy (www.geteasypeasy.com) is another Linux distribution based on Ubuntu. It's almost identical to Ubuntu Netbook Remix but with a different theme. There are a few additional packages in comparison to other operating systems. It comes with Skype and Picasa for example.